

The Last Frontier

Laura Pedersen

If there is such a thing as a dog-eat-dog workplace, the options trading pit comes pretty close. When the trading is in full swing, one of my friends used to say, "The only rule of thumb is to stick it in the other guy's eye before he can stick it in yours."

But the days of the trading floor may be numbered: The entire concept is bound to become an anachronism once the markets become fully automated early in the twenty-first century. Electronic trading has already revolutionized the Cincinnati Stock Exchange, embracing approximately five hundred stocks listed in the U.S., and overseas, with electronic trading, the antiseptic London and Hong Kong stock exchanges now exude as much excitement as a grocery store, even during the busiest trading days.

If there is such a thing as a dog-eat-dog workplace, the options trading pit comes pretty close.

Over the next five years, both the New York Stock Exchange and a consortium led by the American Stock Exchange and Chicago Board of Options Exchange expect to